Courier

By Carol Mack

Set: The play takes place in an unidentified location where the PROFESSOR is being held and in the remembered moments in the PROFESSOR's consciousness.

[Lights up. A man sits on a chair. An INTERROGATOR *stands upstage of him.]*

INTRODUCTION

Since 2001, as part of its War on Terror, the United States' Central Intelligence Agency has operated a network of off-shore detention facilities, commonly known as black sites, which are used as part of the system of extraordinary rendition used to hold and interrogate "high-value" foreign combatants captured during the US's wars in Iraq and Afghanistan. The ACLU has stated they consider extraordinary rendition to be an illegal form of forced disappearance and called for the detainees to receive trials and the camps to be closed; the US government argues that since the combatants are captured while participating in active military conflict against the United States and officially designated as "Illegal Combatants" under the Geneva Convention, the detentions are legal under international law. Courier by Carol Mack explores the concept of extraordinary rendition from a different angle. If our government can detain "foreign" combatants; what is to stop them from detaining U.S. citizens in the name of "National Security." How far is too far in the quest to ensure the "safety" of our Government? Courier by Carol Mack

INTERROGATOR: . . . Go on.

PROFESSOR: So. I'm walking along through the park, my hands clasped behind my back. So ... I'm walking along when it begins to rain ... just then I see a man lying on a bench. I stop to see if he is all right, just sleeping it off, or . . .

INTERROGATOR: And then?

PROFESSOR: . . . then he opens his eyes. Wide. Looks terrified. . . And he grabs my arm. He says, PLEASE. That's all. Please. Stops me cold, that *desperate* sound in his voice. . . he pulls himself up on

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my arm. He feels so light. Weighs no more than a ghost. His face is unshaven. He sits and looks right through me. There's nobody anywhere. Empty paths, vacant benches . . . and I hear him say, "Let me tell you." Then he stops dead as if he hasn't talked to anyone in a long time and his own voice shocks him. I say, like you would to a child, 'It's O.K., what is it? What's wrong?' He says, "Let me tell you how I got here." Then he tells me the story I've already *told* you.

INTERROGATOR: You were supposed to meet him there. You arranged it? Think!

PROFESSOR: I never saw him before! How many times must I -

INTERROGATOR: You're the only people in the whole park, huh?

PROFESSOR: That's right. Fate. Call it what you will. Why am I *here?* . . . [*As* INTERROGATOR *turns away.]* What is this place?! *[As* INTERROGATOR *exits.)* Where is "here"?! [*Angrily to offstage.]* You'll have to let me out soon! They're looking for me! *[To himself, bitterly, fighting to remain himself]* I will not forget the story! I will make notes every day. I won't forget. I'll write it all down bit by bit and when they let me out I'll give them to my wife. Oh, Rachel! . . . *[Very upset.]* You'll send them to the newspapers. In case I . . . am silenced, in case I come home unable to speak or . . . *You'll* find them. *You'll* know what to do. He told me he was "chosen." Chosen! I looked at him like he was crazy.

[Tbe PROFESSOR reappears as the RECRUITER in the remembered scene.]

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YOUNG MAN: *[Linking to remembered moment, on bench as lights shift, Urgently.]* But it's true! Honest. That's how it started. I was chosen, see? out of hundreds of candidates. I was secretly tested. Before the interview. They never said where or how. I mean, all they said was: "You've been selected for the job."

RECRUITER Now, son, we have conducted a thorough search and you have been chosen out of hundreds of potential candidates as most trustworthy. Most reliable. Now, son, this is one of the most important secret government jobs you could ever hope to do. This is about *total trust* in your country, O.K.? This takes a pledge that is way beyond allegiance. This is about faith. That's what we're dealing with here. See that package, son? *That* package and every package must be delivered under *any* circumstances. You never ever ask questions. And, son, if necessary you give your life for your country. And you walk ALONE. Outside this room? Anybody asks what you do for a living, you say you're a part-time whatever but you do NOT say "courier." It could get you killed, son. Got it? *[At nod, he pushes a note across desk.]* These are your instructions. When. Where. How. Memorize it .... Good. There's your first mission. Good luck.

YOUNG MAN: Thank you, sir.

RECRUITER: For what?

YOUNG MAN: Choosing me.

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RECRUITER: For what?

YOUNG MAN: The job?

RECRUITER: What job?

YOUNG MAN: . . . I ... can't say.

RECRUITER: Why not?

YOUNG MAN: 'Cause I don't know?

RECRUITER: Don't know what?

YOUNG MAN: . . . Don't know anything, sir.

RECRUITER: About what? Anything about what?!

YOUNG MAN: Nothing.

RECRUITER: *[As he exits.]* Good!

YOUNG MAN: The packages. They were all sealed. And every day there was a new one. I was taking them to a lab. All these boxes, sealed red boxes. Shiny. Nothing could leak out but ... all going from Central to this lab, see? After a coupla months I wonder who's it going to? And what's in the boxes? All I did was take off the label. Just the label. No name. Some kind of bar code label. I just start to take it off with my penknife- *[Very odd mechanical noise.* YOUNG MAN *startled, stands.]* And before I know it these guys show up, see? Then I get arrested for possession of lethal materials. They accuse me of planning a terrorist attack. They say the box contains a biological weapon. I say that's not possible. They say, "Who do you work for?" I tell them I take the package from Central to the lab. I

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tell them that's my job. They tell me there IS no lab. They tell me there IS no central nothing. That they don't exist and they never have. Then I figure O.K., O.K., this has gotta be some kinda test. Right? Maybe they test you every month. So then they say, "Who do you work for?" and I say, "I ... I used to work for the U.S. post office and I don't work for *nobody* now," and they say, "Then who told you to do it?" *[Breaking down, in tears.]* And I say, "Do *what?"* Do WHAT? For chrissakes! I trusted them. I BELIEVED in them. I was selected for this job and now they turn against me for WHAT

DOCTOR: *[Appears standing with case file, listening, then assured, clinical.]* I see ... Do you know where you are? ... *[At the nod "no. ']* . . . You're in a hospital.

YOUNG MAN: . . . Why?

DOCTOR: So you can get better.

DOCTOR: I have your file here. And your diagnoses. But we *are* going to *cure* you. You'll be all right.

YOUNG MAN: Then do I get out of here? I mean, if I get better?

DOCTOR: Yes. Of course. Absolutely.

YOUNG MAN: How'd they find me? I mean, after I ran away? Does it say in the file?

DOCTOR: Who are "they," these people who "found you"?

YOUNG MAN: I don't know, but they musta thought I was dangerous 'cause they tried to kill me. I got away and I was hiding out in this

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other city and they . . . I could see how they thought maybe I'd talk about the lab? Where I took the stuff? I could-

DOCTOR: Listen, try to hear me out. There is no lab. There is no what you call "Central Office." There is no "package." We know how real these things are to you but they are *not* real, and when you can understand this, you'll feel much better.

YOUNG MAN: I trusted them. I had faith. I trusted my *life* to them. Why?! *[Light shift.]*

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PROFESSOR: *[Alone on chair, remembering, as he was earlier, making a note.]* And by the time he finishes, his face is wet with tears and rain and he starts coughing, then choking and I put my arm around him . . . He twists round and his jacket opens . . . There's a wound. Dark, blackened blood. He twists violently *once* more, then collapses. I take his hand, his wrist. There's no pulse . . . People must die like this every day. Alone. Shot by criminals. He seemed, so . . . *innocent.* I don't know what to think. His story seems incredible. A fantasy. And yet, they were his last words his last story. . . Oh my God. If I hadn't stopped. If I hadn't heard . . . *[Thinking.]* I didn't believe his claim that they could track him. After he escaped the hospital . . . To be *that* . . . able to find him in another city and then to be so near when he tells a stranger his story. Of course I don't know who

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"they" are . . . But suddenly there's a man in uniform ... a policeman.

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POLICEMAN: *[Enters, looking at offstage body and then back at* PROFESSOR.] You found him like that?

PROFESSOR: No, I ... he just started *choking,* then all this blood

POLICEMAN: Hands up. Keep them up. *[Frisking* PROFESSOR, *takes his wallet out, looks at J.D.]* You were just walking by here, huh? You do it a lot? Walk in the rain?

PROFESSOR: It wasn't raining when I started out.

POLICEMAN: So you stop by here and he's lying there bleeding?

PROFESSOR: No! Yes, I mean. I, I didn't, I didn't see the *wound* until

POLICEMAN: And what's your name?

PROFESSOR: Dr. Ahrensky, I teach at Columbia-

POLICEMAN: Ahrensky *[Inspecting wallet.]* What's the origin of this name?

PROFESSOR: How far back? Russia? Aramaic? What are you?

POLICEMAN: Look, you got *blood* on your hands. That guy's dead. "Professor," you're gonna have to answer questions. That guy? You say you never seen him before? He talk to you? Did he *approach* you?

PROFESSOR: No, I . . . I walk by, see he's bleeding, I see *blood,* I see he's been shot.

POLICEMAN: That right? But you said, uh, "I didn't see the wound at first."

PROFESSOR: Did I? I'm . . . I'm quite upset. I need to wash my hands. All

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this blood. I must call my wife, I-

POLICEMAN: Look, we've got a *homicide* here-

PROFESSOR: Are you accusing me of something? If so, I believe you have to read me my rights.

POLICEMAN: You're wrong on that one, "professor," O.K.? Now, how about I do *my* job, you stick to yours. What exactly is your field, professor?

PROFESSOR: Ethics.

POLICEMAN: "Ethics." Look, I gotta know exactly what happened here. How you got involved. We got a dead body. There's blood on your hands. First you say you didn't see the wound. Then you say you did. You say you don't know this person but you're *here,* right?

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PROFESSOR: *[At his chair as at top of play.]* I should've run then. . . But it's Central Park! On Poet's Walk. That's where I was! That's . . . I was in shock. And I *assumed* he was just a cop . . . I assumed the world was a different world . . . I know. I know I'm naive, but then, weren't we all? *[Pause. Then passionately.]* I find it impossible to believe that it has all come to this "life being nasty, brutish and short" and all people against each other like driven mad animals. *[Pause.]* That policeman. I thought he was "only doing his job." He believed that I could kill another human being . . . in the park. In the rain. In some world that . .

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. Had I known we'd come to *this.* HERE?!

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POLICEMAN: So he tells you that whole story?

PROFESSOR: Yes . . . Yes he did.

POLICEMAN: Incredible.

PROFESSOR: Yes. But, officer, somebody shot him-

POLICEMAN: Drugs. Probably drugs. Gangs. But that story . . . Sounds to me like he made up the whole nine yards.

PROFESSOR: . . . I don't know. Poor kid, he seemed so, *lost,* so . . . Yes, I think I *do.* [POLICEMAN *exits.]* Yes. I *do* .... And the world changed . . . The towers fell, and the ivory tower tumbled invisibly and in the rubble, from there to here we fell into another world where I am taken unaware. Yes, I DO! I don't know why I said it. But . . . why would anybody *care* even if I told the story? I am just an old professor . . . And what do I know?! That the boy worked for some , , , *what?* Secret government organization somewhere? Some lab, but *where?* I don't even know *where!* Is it still in operation? What does it *do* that's worth killing for? Worth removing anybody who knows it *exists.* It is impossible to believe that . . . OH God, If you make too much noise. "Yes, I do." Then they put me in a car and bring me here. Poor kid. The "courier" . . . It must be much more complicated to vanish someone with a family . . . Unless you were to take the whole family. Oh, Rachel, please don't do

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anything foolish! . . . I vanished . . . Where to? Why? I was not unhappy. I was not "political,". . . *Please* be careful. Watch what you say. The more you say, the more publicity, the less likely it is I can get out . . . from here. *[Pause.]* But where *is* here? Where are we?

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